

Hybrid by Design

A few of us at work recently got roped in to moderate some panels around the concept of 'Hybrid by Design'. Seems kind of obvious for folks building systems to follow a hybrid approach in order to get the 'best of multiple worlds' but reality is quite different. The term 'Hybrid by Design', a concept which blends the best of multiple worlds—cloud and on-premises infrastructure, personal and professional devices, and diverse ecosystems—promises unparalleled flexibility and adaptability. But while 'Hybrid by Design' seems like an inevitable solution to modern technological needs, is it really the future, or just another layer of complexity that consumers must navigate?

Consider the rise of hybrid cloud systems. It's no longer necessary to choose between keeping sensitive data on-site or taking the leap to the cloud. They offer a flexible middle ground that caters to varied needs. For example, consumers can store large media libraries on a local NAS device for fast access while backing up critical documents to a cloud provider for redundancy and security. I've been doing this for quite some time. Started off with using my old PC as an HTPC which slowly evolved to becoming a backup dump, eventually being hooked up to my cloud storage for the important documents.

Similarly, look at personal gadgets that are designed to blend work and personal life seamlessly. Smartphones are perhaps the ultimate hybrid device. Users can handle work emails, track fitness, and entertain themselves with games or streaming services—all from one pocket-sized device. This kind of hybrid functionality enables a flexible and adaptable user experience, allowing people to shift between work and play effortlessly.

The same concept extends to home technology setups. Devices like smart speakers, TVs, and even routers are designed to operate within a hybrid system. Folks now expect their smart home devices to operate in a fluid manner, where they can control a local device like a thermostat or a home security system from the cloud, or access cloud-based media content through their local devices. This creates an ecosystem that feels cohesive and connected, enhancing the overall user experience.



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Yet, while hybrid technology offers undeniable advantages, it also comes with an inherent trade-off: complexity. Integrating multiple systems often introduces layers of difficulty that can overwhelm even tech-savvy users. Take hybrid cloud systems as an example. While they offer flexibility, managing the intricacies of what data to store locally versus in the cloud can be daunting. IT professionals and consumers alike must navigate the challenges of ensuring compatibility, security, and redundancy. The interface between local and cloud systems isn't always as seamless as one might hope. This can sometimes lead to a situation where the hybrid system becomes more trouble than it's worth, requiring constant attention and technical knowledge that average users might not possess.

In the consumer space, hybrid devices can often suffer from the very flexibility they promise. Laptops that double as tablets sound great in theory, but many models fail to excel in either category. Instead of having the best of both worlds, users often end up with a compromised experience on both ends. Smart home devices are appealing, but the reality is often more frustrating. As more devices are integrated into the home, managing them becomes increasingly complex, and users have to grapple with privacy concerns.

For hybrid technology to succeed in the consumer market, it needs to provide more than just versatility—it must offer simplicity. One of the major issues with hybrid devices is that they often ask too much from the user in terms of management. My colleagues and I have been experiencing this for the past couple of months as we've been juggling between Google Workspace and Microsoft's Office 365. We've worked with Google's services for so long that the transition to Microsoft's services has been rife with frustrating quirks that just don't work the way we expect it to.

The challenge for tech companies is to deliver on the promise of 'Hybrid by Design' without making it a burden for the user. Yes, this would mean an open-standard and most technology domains to move towards an open-standard eventually. It's just that this 'eventuality' takes a really long time. ■